CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

HVAC TECHNICIAN IN THE AI ERA

Every heat wave and cold snap is a full schedule. The work is a license-adjacent, hands-on trade that no app can sweat through for you.

★ TL;DR — Median around $75K, with training in the 1–2 year band and a federal EPA certification as the entry credential. The catch: attics in July and furnaces in January — you work hardest exactly when the weather is worst. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

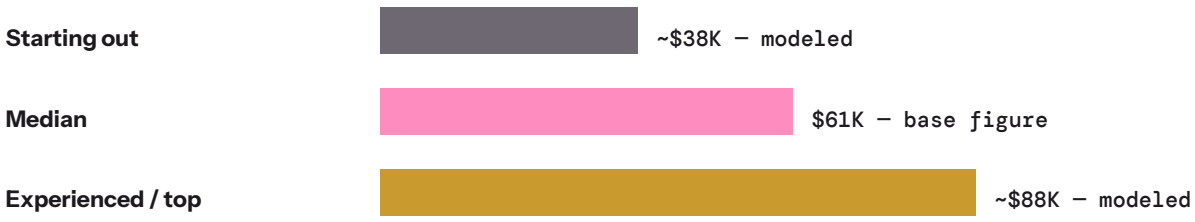
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$61K · TRAINING 1-2 years · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Works because: heating and cooling are not optional in most of the US, and systems fail at peak demand, when companies can charge for speed.
- Bites because: seasonal extremes define the calendar — brutal summer weeks, slow shoulder seasons at some shops.
- AI angle: minimal on the tools side. Smart thermostats and diagnostics help; compressors are still swapped by humans on rooftops.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for HVAC Technician is a ~$61K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A HVAC TECHNICIAN ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Diagnose no-heat and no-cool calls: electrical faults, refrigerant problems, airflow issues, dead components
- ✓ Install and replace furnaces, air conditioners, heat pumps and ductwork
- ✓ Run maintenance: coils, filters, drains, refrigerant charge checks, safety controls
- ✓ Explain repair-vs-replace math to homeowners and document work for warranties

Think: a doctor for the building's lungs and circulation — half electrician, half plumber, half detective, and the math never quite adds to two.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Dispatch, invoicing, and increasingly sensor-driven fault alerts from connected equipment. The alert still ends with a human climbing up with gauges and a multimeter.	Intermittent faults, install craftsmanship, refrigerant handling (legally certified work), and the judgment to condemn a system honestly — or save it. Rooftops and crawlspaces remain robot-free zones.

⚠ **The EPA 608 certification is legally required to handle refrigerants — no certificate, no real HVAC work. And be honest about the physical ledger: rooftop units, attic heat, and on-call nights during heat waves are the job's texture.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Different building, different puzzle, every call ✓ Peak-season earnings with overtime when everyone's system dies at once ✓ A trade with a real ownership path: one truck and a license can become a company	✗ Attic heat in summer is genuinely dangerous, not just unpleasant ✗ On-call rotations and weekend emergencies in peak season ✗ Shoulder-season hours can dip at residential shops

Good fit? You're mechanical and electrical-curious, fine with heights and heat, and you like troubleshooting more than routine. Calm with frustrated homeowners helps.
Bad fit? You wilt in heat, hate being on call, or want clean indoor work. HVAC will test all three in your first summer.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — TRADE SCHOOL + EPA 608	DOOR B — HELPER → APPRENTICE AT A SHOP

Complete an HVAC program at a trade school or community college (inside the 1–2 year band), earn EPA 608 certification, and enter as an install helper or maintenance tech. School gives you the electrical and refrigeration theory shops don't have time to teach.	Get hired as an install helper, learn the physical trade on real jobs, and study for EPA 608 on the side. Many shops promote helpers into service techs — the ones who study electrical troubleshooting between calls.

Smart move: Service techs out-earn and out-last installers: push toward diagnostics early. Learn to read a wiring diagram and a refrigerant circuit like a language, and volunteer for the no-cool calls nobody wants.

Where you land after: Helper → service tech → senior tech / field supervisor → own HVAC company or commercial service roles.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
GET THE	BUILD THE	EARN EPA	GET SHOP	MOVE TO	SPECIALIZE OR

STEP 1 — Get the lay of the land

FREE · TODAY

- Look at local HVAC postings: EPA 608 shows up everywhere — that's your first credential target.
- Decide school vs helper route based on local hiring; both converge at the same skills.

STEP 2 — Build the theory base

MONTHS · 1-2 YR BAND

- Trade school route: refrigeration cycle, electrical fundamentals, heating systems, controls.
- Helper route: same list, self-studied at night while working installs by day.

STEP 3 — Earn EPA 608 certification

EXAM FEE · REQUIRED FOR REFRIGERANT

- Pass the EPA Section 608 exam — Universal type covers all equipment classes and is the version employers want.
- Without it you legally cannot handle refrigerants, which means you cannot do the core work.

STEP 4 — Get shop hours

PAID · MONTHS

- Install crews teach speed and ductwork; maintenance routes teach systems breadth. Take either, learn both.
- State HVAC licensing/registration applies in some states for certain work — check yours and log what's required.

STEP 5 — Move to service and diagnostics

YEAR 1-2

- The pay jump lives in troubleshooting: electrical faults, refrigerant diagnostics, controls.
- Keep a fault log — every weird failure you solve becomes pattern recognition you own.

STEP 6 — Specialize or scale

YEAR 2+

- Commercial/refrigeration work pays more and steadier; heat pumps are the growth specialty in many regions.
- Ownership route: contractor licensing where your state requires it, then your own truck and customers.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: scan local HVAC postings; note EPA 608 and any state requirements that repeat.
- □ Days 1–30: enroll in a program or get hired as a helper; start refrigeration-cycle and electrical basics.
- □ Days 31–60: hands-on reps — installs or maintenance routes; begin EPA 608 exam prep.
- □ Days 61–90: sit the EPA 608 exam; make your intent known at the shop: you want service/diagnostics work.
- □ Day 90: certified or exam-booked, working in the trade, pointed at the service-tech rung.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **WHEN IT BREAKS, YOU'RE THE WEATHER HERO.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and

certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.